

**ECON 204 – Contemporary Economic Issues
Winter 2025**

Instructor Information	
Instructor	Muhebullah Karimzada
Contact Information	✉ karimzada@unbc.ca ☎ Phone: TBA
Office Location & Hours	Online 🕒 1:00 pm – 2:30 pm on Tuesday and Thursday or by appointment
Teaching Assistant	✉ TBA

Course Information	
Lectures	Tuesday and Thursday from 4:00 pm to 5:20 pm
Course Format	Online (Synchronous) – Zoom
Course Description	This course is designed to introduce students to contemporary economics issues, with a particular emphasis on the Canadian and U.S. economies. Topics covered include, but are not limited to, labour market dynamics, income inequality, economic growth, globalization, and international trade. The course will also explore the theory and practice of monetary and fiscal policies in Canada, examining how these policies impact economic stability, growth, and social welfare. Students will gain an understanding of the key economic challenges that Canada is facing today and will develop analytical tools to assess these issues from both a theoretical and practical perspective.
Course Learning Outcomes	At the end of the course, students should be able to • Demonstrate an understanding of major contemporary economic issues, including labor market trends, income inequality, inflation, and housing market challenges. • Use foundational economic theories to analyze and interpret real-world issues within both Canadian and U.S. contexts. • Critically assess the role of monetary and fiscal policies in addressing economic challenges, with a particular focus on Canadian policies. • Interpret economic data related to topics such as employment, trade, and inflation, and use this data to identify trends and make evidence-based conclusions.
Textbook	There is no required textbook for this course. The following are supplementary textbooks. • Acemoglu, Daron (2009). <i>Introduction to Modern Economic Growth</i>. Princeton University Press. • Benjamin, Dwayne, Morley Gunderson, Thomas Lemieux, and W. Craig Riddell (2017). <i>Labour Market Economics</i>. Eighth edition. McGraw-Hill Education. (BGLR) • Krugman, Paul, Maurice Obstfeld, and Marc Melitz. <i>International Economics: Theory and Policy</i>. 12th Edition. Pearson. (KOM)

Course Information	
	- Mishkin, Frederic S. and Apostolos Serletis (2020). <i>The Economics of Money, Banking, and Financial Markets</i>. Eighth Canadian Edition. Pearson. - Rosen, Harvey, Ted Gayer, Lindsay Tedds, Trevor Tombe (2023). <i>Public Finance in Canada</i>. Sixth Edition. McGraw-Hill Education. (RGTT) - Weil, D. N. (2013). <i>Economic growth</i>. Third edition. Pearson Addison-Wesley.
Additional Resources	Additional resources (e.g. lecture slides, practice problem sets) are posted on Moodle. Students are responsible for downloading and saving course material on Moodle before the access to their courses is shut off.

Evaluation & Assessments

Learning in this course results primarily from lectures, in-class discussions, home readings, and practice problem sets. Students learning and progress in this course will be evaluated on individual basis. Grades for this course will be calculated as follows:

Assessment	Weight	Due Date
Term project and presentation	30%	Final draft due on Mar 31 st , 2025
Midterm exam 1	15%	February 6 th , 2025
Midterm exam 2	15%	March 20 th , 2025
Final Exam	40%	TBA
Total	100%	

Course schedule by week

Week	Date	Topic	Readings
1	Jan 6 – 12	Introduction to Contemporary Economic Issues • An overview of the course • Discussion of the key issues in the Canadian and global Economy	• Notes
2 & 3	Jan 13 - 26	Labour Market • Unemployment • Effects of Automation and Artificial Intelligence on Employment • COVID19 and the labour market • Gig economy and changing labour market dynamics	• Notes • Chapter 16 (BGLR)
4 & 5	Jan 27 – Feb 9	Income Inequality • Analysis of income distribution • Measurement of inequality using the Gini coefficient • Measurement of the level of poverty • The evolution of inequality in Canada and in other countries • Observed relationships between poverty, inequality, and the average income	• Notes • Chapter 13 (David N. Weil)
6	Feb 10 - 16	Economic Growth • The evolution of the standard of living in the world • The importance of economic growth in the evolution of the standard of living •	• Notes • Chapter 1 (D. Acemoglu)
Mid-Semester Break			
7	Feb 24 – Mar 2	Economic Growth Cont'd • Evaluation of the level of convergence and conditional convergence among countries • Identification of variables that correlate with economic growth	• Notes • Chapter 1 (D. Acemoglu)

8 & 9	Mar 3 - 16	Globalization and International Trade - History and theories of international trade - Benefits and drawbacks of globalization - Trade wars, tariffs, and the role of international trade organizations	- Notes - Chapter 3 (KOM)
10 & 11	Mar 17 - 30	Public Finance - Sources of a government revenue. - Components of a government expenditure. - Measurement and interpretation of public debt. - Analysis of the impact of fiscal policies on the economic activity during COVID19 period and post-COVID19 period.	- Notes - Chapter 15-16 (Mishkin and Serletis)
12	Mar 31 – Apr 6	Housing Market in Canada	Notes

Please Note:

- For some chapters selected portions will be covered as a part of the course material.
- If a student misses a lecture for any reason, it is student's responsibility to obtain class lecture notes and other relevant material.
- Details of the term project and presentation will be discussed during the first week of lectures, and all relevant information will be posted on Moodle.
- There will be no make-up midterms.
- If a midterm exam is missed, given proper documentation, 50% of the missed midterm weight will be transferred to the other midterm and the remaining 50% of the weight will be allocated to the final exam. Students must write at least one midterm exam.
- All exams, midterms and final, are individual and closed-book.
- Both the midterms and the final exam will consist of a mix of short answer questions, analytical problems, numerical calculations, mathematical derivations, true-false, multiple choice, and fill-in-the-blank questions, and will draw on material covered in the lectures.
- Your grades on midterms will be posted on Moodle. Please immediately report to the instructor any discrepancy between the posted and actual grades.
- Only the Registrar's Office can issue final grades. Hence, marks for the final exam will not be posted on Moodle.
- You are encouraged to contact course instructor or course TA for any questions on the course material and outlines, evaluation scheme, and the final exam.

Artificial Intelligence (AI)

Use of generative AI is NOT allowed in this course, unless specifically authorized by the instructor. Please consult with the instructor if any clarification is needed. General guidance on the acceptability of using generative AI at UNBC can be found [here](#).

Plagiarism

Plagiarism is a misrepresentation of information that can result in a misattribution of credit, up to and including representing someone else's work as your own. When you incorporate the words, ideas, graphics, or other products from someone else's work into your projects, you must give credit by providing a citation and reference to the source work.

It is your responsibility to:

1. Familiarize yourself with and understand the information on [plagiarism](#) provided by the Academic Success Centre,
2. And the UNBC policy on Student Conduct, plagiarism and other academic offenses, as described in the UNBC Undergraduate calendar.

Grading System - Undergraduate Assessments

Grade Point	Letter Grade	Percentage	Definition/Standing
4.33	A+	90 -100%	Excellent
4.00	A	85-89.9%	
3.67	A-	80-84.9%	
3.33	B+	77-79.9%	Good
3.00	B	73-76.9%	
2.67	B-	70-72.9%	
2.33	C+	70-72.9%	Satisfactory
2.00	C	63-66.9%	
1.67	C-	60-62.9%	Marginal
1.33	D+	57-59.9%	
1.00	D	53-56.9%	
0.67	D-	50-62.9%	
0.00	F	0-49.9%	Failure

Student Services

University students often encounter setbacks from time to time that can impact academic performance. If you experience difficulties and need assistance, it's important to reach out. The following resources are available **free** to all students at UNBC and can help address mental, emotional, or physical health concerns:

General IT & Moodle Support

IT Services can assist you with accessing your UNBC account or Moodle, please email support@unbc.ca or visit their [Support for Students](#) page. If you have specific questions or errors while uploading assignments, using video, Kaltura etc. contact the Centre for Teaching Learning & Technology at ctl@unbc.ca.

Academic Advising

For questions regarding course load, understanding your degree requirements or your GPA please reach out to Academic Advising located in the Enrollment Services Room 7-702.

Webpage: [Student Advising](#)

Phone: 250-960-6306

Email: advising@unbc.ca

The Academic Success Centre (ASC)

The Academic Success Centre provides students with free access to academic support services: Tutoring (by appointment, asynchronous online, or drop-in), personalized study skills assessments and peer-led course supports. ASC services are available in person (room 5-139) at the Prince George Campus and online

Webpage: [Academic Success Centre](#)

Phone: 250-960-6367 | Toll Free 1-888-440-3440

Email: asc@unbc.ca

Access Resource Centre (ARC)

The Access Resource Centre (ARC) provides services to students with documented health conditions and/or disabilities. ARC staff are available to meet with you to determine which academic accommodation can be put in place to support you in achieving their academic goals, provide referrals, and help advocate for you.

Webpage: [Access Resource Centre](#)

Phone: 250-960-5682 | Toll Free 1-888-960-5682

Email: arc@unbc.ca

UNBC Counselling Services

Offers counseling for all students as well as access to First Nations Counseling Services

Offers health and general services that support academic success and personal wellbeing of students

Webpage: [UNBC Counselling Services](#)

Phone: 250-960-6369

Email: wellness@unbc.ca

Crisis Centre for Northern BC (24/7)

If you are feeling overwhelmed, depressed, confused, suicidal, or just needing someone to listen to, the crisis line provides emotional support, suicide intervention and referral information. If you are unable to meet course expectations due to mental health reasons, please discuss your situation with your instructor, counsellor or/and an academic advisor.

Webpage: <https://crisis-centre.ca/>

Phone: Northern BC: [1-888-562-1214](tel:1-888-562-1214) | Youth Support: [1-888-564-8336](tel:1-888-564-8336) | Anywhere in BC: [1-800-784-2433](tel:1-800-784-2433)

UNBC SAFE app

UNBC SAFE features emergency contacts, services, information and safety tips. Emergency messaging can be sent to you via Push notifications when enabled. Download the App [here](#).

UNBC Athletics

Please note that students involved in University Athletics will be required to notify the instructor at least two weeks in advance of any official athletics commitments (e.g., games, travel) that conflict with due dates.

Food Security

We understand the cost of living is higher than ever, and it's hard to learn when you're hungry. The [NUGSS Food Bank](#) (located in the NUGSS office in Building 6) is open to all students.